2010 round collected biometrics. Later seeded into Aadhaar, the biometric requirement was subsequently dropped. The questionnaire itself expanded from 14 queries in 2010 to 21 in later rounds. In 2020, the Modi government announced another NPR update, but widespread protests and the COVID pandemic stalled it. Critics focused on two new questions—date and place of birth of parents—arguing that this was a veiled attempt to trace ancestry and target certain communities under the guise of citizenship verification.

Experts, however, caution that uninformed resistance should not be used to dilute the larger issue of illegal immigration. Prof. Mishra says any attempt to link illegal immigration with national security must be seen in a historical context, particularly against the backdrop of terrorism and India's vulnerable borders with hostile neighbours. Rami Niranjan Desai, an anthropologist specialising in northeast India, argues that the Assam experience should not be grounds to abandon the NRC altogether. Instead, she says, the process needs refinement, less dependence on documents, more layers of verification, stronger checks and balances and multiple opportunities for appeal. Though time-consuming, such safeguards are essential to make the exercise both fair and effective.

A Picture in Numbers

The debate over illegal immigration is built on numbers that shift wildly depending on the source. In 1997, home minister Indrajit Gupta, a Left politician, put the figure at 10 million; by 2001, a task force on border management raised it to 15 million. In 2004, Sriprakash Jaiswal, who was minister of state for home affairs then, told Parliament there were 12 million Bangladeshis in India. By 2016, the then MoS for home affairs Kiren Rijiju claimed "around 20 million", though he admitted that clandestine entry made reliable estimates impossible.

Experts are wary about attributing such changes solely to illegal immigration, as fertility differentials, though narrowing, account for much of the growth gap. The rise in Muslim population in a non-border state like, say, Madhya Pradesh fortifies that analysis, showing that immigration alone cannot explain the pattern. "There has been no fresh data on de-



"There is a definite element of the NRC in the SIR exercise, given the EC's insistence on checking citizenship and its extreme reluctance to accept Aadhaar"

— YOGENDRA YADAV, *Political activist*



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

WHAT IS SIR?

Bihar's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls stands out for its tight deadline and voter-specific documentation rules, marking a departure from earlier nationwide exercises

- **While the ECI has conducted at least nine such revisions between 1952 and 2004—some involving house-to-house verification or even a complete *de novo* (anew) roll—Bihar's exercise is exceptional**
- **For the first time, a full-state intensive revision has been conducted just four to six months ahead of assembly elections, combining a hybrid approach with a compressed schedule**
- **Bihar's last intensive revision happened in 2002-03, part of a larger nationwide effort. While the enumeration phase ran for 31 days in mid-2002—the same as this year—the revision was completed a full three years before the assembly polls in October 2005, allowing ample time for corrections, appeals, etc.**